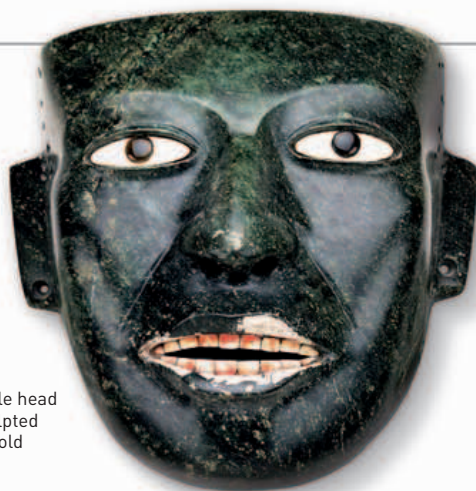




eagle head
sculpted
in gold

Lip ornament
AZTEC/MIXTEC

This eagle-shaped lip plug, or labret, would have been worn by a member of the Aztec elite. The Mixtec, a conquered tribe, made most Aztec gold jewelry.



Human mask
AZTEC

Found at the Great Temple of the Aztecs in their capital Tenochtitlán (now Mexico City), this greenstone mask was a votive offering.



Warrior effigy pot
MOCHE

This pot from the Moche culture of the north coast of Peru shows a warrior in a headdress grasping a club. Constant warfare was a way of life.



sharp
obsidian blade

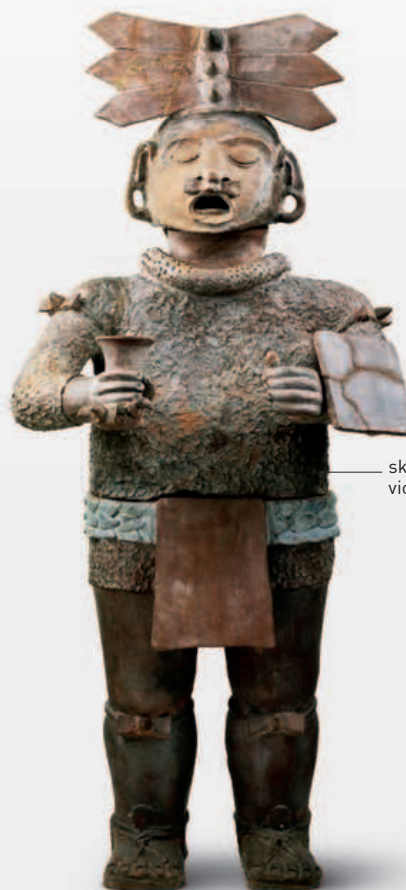


Obsidian knife
AZTEC

Long-bladed, razor-sharp obsidian knives such as this one were used by warriors and in the gory human sacrifices practiced by the Aztecs.

Maquahuitl
AZTEC

Lacking iron or steel, pre-Columbian Americans used obsidian (volcanic glass) to form cutting edges. The *maquahuitl*—a wooden club fringed with obsidian blades—was a common Aztec weapon.



skin of flayed
victim

Xipe Totec, god of the springtime
AZTEC

The name of this grisly god translates as "our flayed lord"; he is depicted wearing the skin of a sacrificial victim, denoting the spring renewal of the Earth's "skin."



Priceless heart
AZTEC

The heart was considered the most precious organ that could be offered to the gods, and this replica was carved in jade, which the Aztecs regarded as their most valuable substance.

THE AZTECS, INCAS, AND MAYA

THE EXTRAORDINARY ARTISTIC TRADITIONS OF PRE-COLUMBIAN AMERICA THAT SPANNED MILLENNIA

The Incas, Aztecs, and Maya were advanced civilizations with sophisticated arts and crafts and highly developed graphic systems. The artifacts they created dazzled the medieval European invaders and still fascinate today.

The art and culture of the pre-Columbian civilizations of Mesoamerica and the Andes represent the height of ancient traditions stretching back to the 4th millennium BCE. The conquistadors had a devastating effect on these cultures, but the artifacts that survive are a testament to their rich heritage. Much of Incan culture came from client states, such as the Moche, while the Aztecs and Mayans derived theirs from older cultures, such as the Olmecs.

Sun stone
AZTEC

This sun stone, or calendar stone, is the largest Aztec sculpture ever found. It represents the Aztecs' mythical history of the universe. The Sun, believed to have been formed in the most recent era of creation, is at the center.

decorated with
pictographs

band showing
days of month

disc is 13 ft (4 m)
across

